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Lexington is latest to wield budget ax

Mounting financial woes bedevil even top-ranked schools in state

By James Vaznis
GLOBE STAFF

Lexington has long been held up as a gold standard for public education, with well-funded schools and students who have among the highest test scores in Massachusetts.

But like many other school

districts in the state, Lexington is confronting an acute shortage of money, and its plan to rein in spending will result in considerable changes to classrooms come September.

The school district this week announced the full-time equivalent about 65 teachers, class-

room aides, and other staff positions would be eliminated, and that it will issue non-renewal letters to about 160 early-career educators. Lexington has the full-time equivalent of approximately 600 teachers, according to state data.

The move comes less than six months after Lexington voters approved a tax increase to fund the construction of a new high school, which at some

\$660 million is one of the most expensive ever in Massachusetts. The town also is bracing for an onslaught of new housing that could lead to more children in the school system.

“What Lexington is facing isn’t the exception — it’s the rule. Half of Massachusetts school districts are wrestling with the same pressures we are,” Lexington Superintendent Julie Hackett said in a state-

ment to the Globe about the operating budget challenges.

Separately she also acknowledged the cuts, first reported by the Lexington Observer, have an inescapable human element.

“Behind every staffing decision is a real person, and we have not arrived at these choices lightly, knowing the impact they carry,” Hackett wrote in a

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BSO president Chad Smith

BSO vows to heal rift with musicians

Leader offers glimpse of future after Nelsons’ exit

By Malcolm Gay
GLOBE STAFF

In his first extensive remarks since the dismissal of conductor Andris Nelsons, Boston Symphony Orchestra president Chad Smith acknowledged an urgent need to repair relations with the orchestra’s musicians, who were blindsided by Nelsons’ ouster and are fuming at their bosses.

“We have a lot of work to do to rebuild trust with the musicians,” Smith said Friday, saying it will be “a major focus for me and the board going forward.”

Smith and other BSO leaders have come under withering criticism since they announced Nelsons’ contract would not be renewed, offering little more explanation than that the conductor wasn’t “aligned on future vision.”

Audiences want a fuller explanation and a coherent vision. BSO musicians, deeply loyal to Nelsons, said Smith no longer has their “trust or buy-in,” and

BSO, Page A10

Immigrant leader faces smuggling charges

By Paul Heintz
GLOBE STAFF

On dirt roads in far northern Vermont, José Ignacio De La Cruz allegedly would meet subjects who had illegally crossed the Canadian border by foot and ferry them to a new life in the United States, federal prosecutors said this week.

De La Cruz is a leader of Migrant Justice, a Vermont-based immigrant rights group behind a raucous protest in South Burlington earlier in March that devolved into a violent confrontation with federal immigration authorities.

Now he is accused of engaging in “multi-year conspiracies” to smuggle undocumented people into the US and fraudulently acquire driver’s licenses for others.

A federal grand jury returned a nine-count indictment last month charging De La Cruz, 30, of Burlington, and other unnamed co-conspirators with the crimes. He was arrested on his way to work Thursday and

ACTIVIST, Page A5



COLOR, GRACE IN MOTION

Eden McMurray warmed up in a dressing room before performing Friday at the Youth America Grand Prix ballet scholarship auditions at the Hanover Theatre for the Performing Arts in Worcester. At right, Kiera Lu also auditioned at the theater. The event runs through Sunday. **B2.**



PHOTOS BY ERIN CLARK/GLOBE STAFF

Eng looks to Far East for transit inspiration

As World Cup nears here, he makes his own global stops

By Danny McDonald
GLOBE STAFF

This summer, Greater Boston will be part of the backdrop to the globe’s largest sporting event: the FIFA World Cup.

The success of the tournament here — the region’s ability to absorb 2 million visitors — will hinge, at

least partially, on the MBTA. So where to look for small but important ways to ensure out-of-towners know where they’re going?

For Phil Eng, the state’s most important transportation official, the answer may lie in Singapore, Seoul, or Tokyo.

Eng, both the T’s general manager and the state’s interim transportation secretary, visited all three locales as part of a \$14,000 two-week transit junket last November, a trip paid for by the T that took Eng across the globe just weeks after he

took on his second job at Governor Maura Healey’s request.

The public transit pilgrimage, which has not been previously reported, was worthwhile, Eng said, because it exposed him to innovations of other transit agencies, including initiatives large and small: from developing their properties with housing and retail, to modeling effective signage for their million of riders each day.

Signage is top of mind for Eng, as the T prepares to direct tens of

ENG, Page A10

COMMENTARY

For them, all that glitters is gold

Those seeking Trump’s favor find nothing smooths way like a gift

By James Pindell
GLOBE STAFF

The fund-raiser started, fittingly, with a golden statue that didn’t exist until the moment someone thought it would be needed.

At the Republican event this week, House Speaker Mike Johnson unveiled what he called the first-ever “America First Award.” It was a golden eagle trophy created for the occasion and immediately handed to Donald Trump. Johnson suggested it would become an annual thing.

It makes sense if you didn’t hear about this because it has become so common with the president. But years into this exercise it’s worth stepping back and asking: How did this even begin?

While many nonprofit groups bestow an honor on someone with the hope of get-

TRUMP, Page A6

Mercurial

Saturday: Temps tumble. High 36-41, low 26-31.

Sunday: Temps rise. High 46-51, low 27-32.

Weather and comics, **D4-5.**

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NEXT IN LINE?

The Homeland Security mess continued both in the terminals of airports such as John F. Kennedy International in New York and in the chambers of Congress as the House rejected a Senate plan to end most of the shutdown. **A2.**

Parents said they have raised enough money to keep the Jamaica Plain branch of the troubled Croft School system open until the end of the academic year. B1.